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Turangalîla is fatal love that fulfills, writes Giller winner Sean Michaels, mascot of early electronic instruments

I was in Calgary for a turangalîla. Snow everywhere, like the sky had decided to throw a vicious, ice-blown party. A thousand of us all warm and well lit inside the downtown Epcor Centre

By [Special to National Post](#)

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Chris Tait for National Post

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I was in Calgary for a turangalîla. Snow everywhere, like the sky had decided to throw a vicious, ice-blown party. A thousand of us all warm and well lit inside the downtown Epcor Centre, murmuring five syllables as if they were magic words. *Turangalîla*: a word invented by 20th-century composer Olivier Messiaen, jamming together two Sanskrit terms. *Turangalîla*: the name of Messiaen's sole "symphony," almost 60 years old, which was finally receiving its Alberta debut.

The delay wasn't entirely surprising. Although it's unquestionably one of the 20th century's most important orchestral compositions, staging *Turangalîla* takes a gutsy audience and an even gutsier arts organization, as well as full string, brass and woodwind sections, at least eight percussionists, a virtuoso pianist, four types of cymbal, vibraphone, glockenspiel, celesta — and ondes martenot.



I was here for the ondes: Since winning the Giller for a novel about the inventor of the theremin — a warbling gizmo played by moving hands in the air — I’ve become a sort of mascot for early electronic musical instruments. On this particular Saturday night I was invited to wave from the stage — like a thereminist, I guess, or one of those herky-jerky, wind-filled balloon-men outside of car dealerships.

Programming *Turangalila* is an act of courage. Here, the Calgary Philharmonic Orchestra also hedged their bets. Before unfurling Messiaen’s 10 cacophonous movements, they offered two creampuffs: an unfussy, almost stolid, performance of the *Marseillaise*, Albertan vim standing in for Gallic patriotism; and an excellent rendition of Saint-Saëns’ evergreen *Carnival of the Animals*, with piano duo Anderson & Roe.

TRENDING 🔥



Finally the lights dimmed and we all murmured again, like enchanters

Greg Anderson and Elizabeth Joy Roe, Calgary's visiting YouTube stars, clowned at their keyboards, hammed it up; Roe kept flinching from her keyboard, bangs flying, as if she were experiencing the recoil of a weapon. But the duo also served their hosts. I admired the unexpected quiet of the piece: conductor Roberto Minczuk gave ample room to every gentle arrival and slow fading, from "Cuckoo"'s hilarious whack-a-mole to "Aquarium"'s bioluminescent shiver. "Tortoises," often one of Saint-Saëns' snoozers, became a misty wonder. It was only a pity that "The Swan" seemed so saccharine. Clara Rockmore's shattering theremin version plays a central role in *Us Conductors*; here, for piano and cello, the musicians paddled past the minor chords. It was never fragile, merely serene.

Then finally the lights dimmed and we all murmured again, like enchanters, "turangalîla." When the lights came up, we were seeing every colour. For this landmark performance of Messiaen's

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symphony, the CPO partnered with a team of students and instructors from the Alberta College of Art and Design. They laser-mapped the Jack Singer Concert Hall, perched a panoply of projectors, sewed together an array of custom animation, early film clips, rays and rays of banded light. As Minczuk raised his baton and the basses roared out in blacks and blues, the Singer's pipe organ was painted the same spectral colours — columns of rainbow that shimmered and changed, activated by the musicians' own movements.

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The mesmerizing sixth movement was a clear highlight,

with lilting flute and ondes, like a delicate riddle

Messiaen defined turangalîla as “a love that is fatal,” a love that “invokes death [and] transcends the body ... extending on a cosmic scale.” In Calgary, this love sounded like thrilling din. Swoops of cello and viola, updrafts of frenetic violin, bells and percussion like a kind of weather — dusting and gusting through the hall, containing the clamour. A piece of majestic, sustained tension: the sense of relentless searching, without rest or resolution. There was awe — the so-called “statue” motif, a fanfare of horns, indomitable as death. And there was beauty, too — the mesmerizing sixth movement, a clear highlight, with lilting flute and ondes, like a delicate riddle.

Throughout it all, images crested and cycled overhead. Projections of flying embers, darting birds, blooms of colour as stand-ins for Messiaen’s synesthesia. But I was most impressed by the use of film clips, overseen, I think, by Kaylee Novakovski. Women’s mirrored faces, in black and white — sighing, grimacing, running away, closing their eyes in defeat.

A million kisses, too — theatrical clasps during *Turangalîla*'s “love theme” — but mostly the men appeared only briefly, mysteriously. They seemed like ambivalent forces, maybe even treacherous. Through this lens, *Turangalîa* was reconfigured: “fatal love” too often has a cause. Among the revels of lover and lover, there are a million dangers and capitulations. Violence has victims.

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This roiling, feminist cacophony was too much for some people

This roiling, feminist cacophony was too much for some people. Over the course of the piece's 70 minutes, about as many people made for the doors. But if you can't take the heat, keep out of the kitchen. How rarely we hear a piece as tumultuous as this played with so much bareheartedness and presence. How rarely do we get to learn such lessons of fulfillment and disintegration, with an ondes martenot like antifreeze in the wine. As soloist Christopher Mokrzewski pounded on his piano, all graceful

discombobulation, I couldn't shake the image of a lover listening closely to their partner's garbled pocket-dial. Hunting for a reassurance or a clue.

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—Sean Michaels is the Giller Prize-winning author of *Us Conductors*.

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